



LOST BOYS CYBER

THREAT INTELLIGENCE • MALWARE ANALYSIS • DETECTION ENGINEERING



Check Point reports ransomware attacks jump 48% year over year despite decline in overall cyberattack activity

Malware Analysis

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TLP:CLEAR | Lost Boys Cyber | Check Point reports ransomware attacks jump 48% year over year despite decline in overall cyberattack activity - Malware Analysis

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Check Point May 2026 Ransomware Surge: Qilin, The Gentlemen, and DragonForce Activity Amid Lower Overall Attack Volume

1. Executive Summary

Check Point Research reported that global cyberattack volume eased in May 2026 after April's rebound, but ransomware activity accelerated sharply. Organizations experienced an average of 2,055 weekly cyberattacks, a 2% year-over-year increase and a 7% month-over-month decline, while reported ransomware incidents reached 698 globally, up 48% from 472 in May 2025. The reduction in aggregate attack volume should not be read as lower operational risk: ransomware activity grew across Asia, EMEA, and the Americas, and the ecosystem continued to fragment into a large number of active brands and affiliate programs.

This report is a source-based malware and ransomware ecosystem assessment rather than a single-sample reverse-engineering report. No executable sample, hash, sandbox trace, or leak-site scrape was provided with the intake. The analysis therefore focuses on the ransomware families and intrusion-enabling behaviors identified in the source reporting: Qilin, The Gentlemen, and DragonForce led May 2026 published ransomware activity, while 58 additional active groups accounted for the remaining 61% of reported attacks. The business implication for defenders is that ransomware readiness cannot be scoped around one dominant brand or one malware family; controls must detect common pre-encryption tradecraft, credential abuse, exfiltration staging, endpoint-defense tampering, lateral movement, and unusual file encryption at scale.

Industrial manufacturing is directly relevant to Lost Boys Cyber clients. Check Point reported that industrial manufacturing ransomware victims climbed 50% year over year, while business services represented 35% of all ransomware victims and consumer goods/services increased 223%. For manufacturing and OT-adjacent organizations, the priority is to validate identity exposure, remote-access hardening, backup recoverability, segmentation, and detection coverage before encryption becomes visible on endpoints.

Immediate defender actions are: inventory and harden internet-facing VPN and remote-access systems, monitor for ransomware staging behaviors, enforce MFA and privileged-access boundaries, validate EDR tamper alerts, review GenAI data-loss controls, and rehearse recovery procedures using scenarios where affiliates move from access brokerage to data theft and encryption within compressed timelines.

2. Sample Metadata

Because the intake is based on public reporting about ransomware ecosystem activity, this section records campaign-level metadata rather than sample-level artefacts. No malware binary was obtained or detonated during this review.

Field	Value
Report ID	LBC-MA-2026-016
Subject	May 2026 ransomware surge and leading active ransomware groups
Primary Families / Brands	Qilin, The Gentlemen, DragonForce; additional active ransomware groups not individually enumerated in the source
Malware Type	Ransomware / double-extortion and affiliate-driven intrusion operations
Platform	Enterprise Windows, Linux, ESXi, NAS, VPN, identity, and cloud environments are plausible targets based on modern ransomware operations; platform-specific samples were not provided
Primary Sample SHA256	Not available; no single sample was provided
Additional Hashes	Not available

File Type / Format	Not applicable to source-only campaign reporting
Delivery / Access Themes	Affiliate access brokerage, internet-facing remote-access exploitation, credential abuse, lateral movement, data theft, endpoint-defense evasion, encryption
First Seen / Reported	Source article published 2026-06-12, covering May 2026 activity
Analyst Confidence	Medium overall; high for quoted Check Point aggregate metrics, medium for inferred defensive mappings and generic ransomware tradecraft
Primary Objective	Extortion through data theft, encryption, business disruption, and victim pressure

3. Source Review and Confidence

Source	Contribution	Confidence
Check Point Research blog, "Global Cyber Attacks Ease in May 2026, But Ransomware Surges 48% as Threats Reorganize"	Primary source for attack-volume, ransomware, sector, regional, GenAI, and group-share metrics	High for metrics as vendor-reported telemetry; medium for ecosystem interpretation
Industrial Cyber article summarizing Check Point reporting	Sector-focused intake source highlighting relevance to industrial manufacturing, agriculture, construction, and critical-infrastructure-adjacent sectors	Medium-high; mostly restates Check Point data with industrial-sector framing
Public secondary summaries on Qilin, DragonForce, and The Gentlemen	Context for likely ransomware operating models and defensive assumptions where the primary article did not provide sample-level detail	Medium; used only for generic tradecraft framing, not for hard IOCs
Internal analysis	Detection, hunting, and recommendations mapped from reported ransomware trends and common enterprise telemetry	Medium; no local sandbox execution was possible without samples

Directly observed evidence in the source material includes the May 2026 ransomware counts, year-over-year growth rates, sector shares, regional shares, GenAI exposure statistics, and named leading groups. High-confidence assessment: ransomware risk increased despite a modest decline in overall cyberattack volume, and the operational burden shifted toward defending against a diversified affiliate economy rather than a small set of predictable operators. Lower-confidence inference: individual incidents attributed to Qilin, The Gentlemen, or DragonForce in May may vary substantially by affiliate, tooling, initial-access path, and encryption payload.

Analyst assumptions used in this report:

- No single sample is available; therefore static and code analysis are not claimed.
- Detection engineering emphasizes behavior and telemetry patterns common to ransomware intrusions rather than hash-based signatures.
- References to FortiGate access, EDR evasion, white-label operations, and affiliate recruitment are used as contextual risk indicators and should be validated against client-specific telemetry before operationalizing response actions.

4. Infection Chain Analysis

Ransomware incidents represented in the source reporting are best modeled as multi-stage intrusions rather than isolated malware executions. The May 2026 dataset shows broad acceleration across geographies and sectors, which is consistent with affiliate-driven operations using a mix of vulnerability exploitation, credential abuse, access brokers, and commodity post-exploitation tooling.

Stage	Likely Activity	Evidence / Rationale	Defensive Focus
Initial access	VPN or edge-device exploitation, stolen credentials, phishing, RDP exposure, access-broker purchase	The Gentlemen reporting references pre-exploited FortiGate access; modern ransomware groups frequently use exposed remote access	Patch edge devices, enforce MFA, monitor unusual VPN geographies and impossible travel
Establish foothold	Interactive shell, web shell, remote-management tool, scheduled task, service, or legitimate admin tool	Affiliate programs require flexible tradecraft across victim environments	Alert on new services, LOLBIN chains, unsigned remote tools, abnormal admin activity
Discovery	AD, network share, backup, virtualization, and security-tool discovery	Ransomware crews need to identify high-value systems before extortion	Detect enumeration bursts, LDAP/AD module usage, share crawling, backup-console access
Privilege escalation and lateral movement	Credential theft, pass-the-hash, remote service creation, SMB/WMI/WinRM/RDP movement	Common pre-encryption behavior; not unique to one family	Correlate credential access with new remote logons and service creation
Defense evasion	EDR tampering, userland evasion, disablement of backups and logging	Check Point cited The Gentlemen communications moving from brute-force EDR killing toward surgical userland evasion	Monitor tamper events, protected-process failures, security service stops, driver loads
Data staging / exfiltration	Archive creation, cloud transfer tools, unusual outbound transfers, DLS preparation	Double extortion is a core ransomware operating model; DragonForce offers affiliate extortion support	Monitor compression tools, bulk file reads, outbound transfer spikes, unsanctioned cloud tools
Encryption and impact	File encryption, ransom note deployment, virtualization/NAS targeting, production disruption	Ransomware incidents are counted as published attacks; impact likely includes encryption or extortion pressure	Detect high file-renaming/writing rates, ransom-note creation, ESXi/NAS anomalies

4.1 Process Tree and Execution Chain Model

No specific process tree was observed in a sandbox. The following model is provided as an analytic sequence defenders can use to scope telemetry during suspected ransomware pre-encryption activity.

Step	Parent / Source	Child / Action	Why It Matters
1	VPN / edge appliance / exposed remote service	New authenticated session from unusual ASN, country, or device fingerprint	Often precedes affiliate hands-on-keyboard activity
2	Compromised user context	`cmd.exe`, `powershell.exe`,	Establishes execution path for

		`wscript.exe`, `rundll32.exe`, `regsvr32.exe`, or remote- management binary	discovery and staging
3	Interactive shell / admin tool	AD and network discovery commands such as `nltest`, `net view`, `whoami /groups`, `quser`, `ipconfig /all`	Maps victim environment and identifies privilege path
4	Privileged session	Remote service creation, WMI, PsExec-like activity, RDP/SMB lateral movement	Moves toward backup, file, domain, and virtualization servers
5	Staging host	Archive creation with `7z`, `rar`, `tar`, `robocopy`, `rclone`, `mega`, or similar transfer utility	Indicates pre-encryption theft and extortion preparation
6	Security control target	Service stop, driver load, EDR tamper event, process injection, or userland bypass	Reduces probability of interruption before encryption
7	Broad host set	Ransomware execution, ransom-note creation, high- volume file writes/renames	Business-impact phase; requires immediate containment

5.1 Static Findings

No payload was provided, so file-level static analysis was not performed. The technical findings below are campaign-level and source-derived.

Static / Campaign Signal	Evidence	Analyst Value
Ransomware activity accelerated sharply	698 reported attacks in May 2026, up 48% from 472 in May 2025	Treat ransomware readiness as a current operational priority even when total attack volume declines
Ecosystem fragmentation persisted	61 active ransomware groups, with the top three accounting for 39% and the remaining 58 groups accounting for 61%	Avoid brand-only detection strategies; behavior-based coverage is required
Qilin led published attacks	14% of published attacks	Qilin and displaced affiliate tradecraft should be prioritized in threat briefings and tabletop scenarios
The Gentlemen emerged rapidly	10% of published attacks, reportedly zero recorded activity in May 2025	New groups can reach material victim share quickly; watch for affiliate migration and rebranding
DragonForce expanded	8% of published attacks, with white-label affiliate model context	Attribution may be obscured by affiliate branding; detect infrastructure and behavior, not only ransom note names
Industrial manufacturing exposure increased	Industrial manufacturing ransomware activity climbed 50% year over year	Manufacturing clients require OT/IT recovery and segmentation validation
GenAI data exposure risk is material	1 in 25 enterprise GenAI prompts carried high sensitive-data leakage risk; 91% of regular users' organizations touched by the	Incorporate GenAI governance into data- loss and extortion-prevention programs

	risk	
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5.2 Code and Capability Assessment

No disassembly, decompilation, strings extraction, config extraction, or unpacking was completed because the source did not include payloads. Instead, capability assessment is derived from the operational requirements of the ransomware activity described.

Capability	Evidence Basis	Defensive Implication
Extortion operations	Reported ransomware incidents and published victim activity	Detection must cover theft and pressure operations, not only encryption
Affiliate-driven deployment	61 active groups and white-label / affiliate recruitment references	Initial access, tools, and infrastructure may vary between incidents using the same brand
Defense evasion	Source references The Gentlemen moving away from brute-force EDR killing toward surgical userland evasion	Security teams should monitor subtle tampering, process injection, suspicious module loads, and unsigned tooling
Edge-device access and exploitation	The Gentlemen context around pre-exploited FortiGate access	VPN telemetry, firmware lifecycle, and config auditing are ransomware controls, not only network hygiene tasks
Multi-sector targeting	Education, government, telecom, business services, consumer goods/services, agriculture, construction, manufacturing	Sector-specific assumptions are weak; prioritize exposure and business-impact modeling

5.3 Dynamic Behavior Assessment

No live malware execution was performed. The following dynamic behaviors are expected to be high-value telemetry pivots for ransomware operations matching the reported threat landscape.

Behavior	Telemetry Source	Suspicious Pattern	Response Priority
VPN account misuse	VPN, IdP, firewall, EDR logon data	New country/ASN, no MFA, impossible travel, new device, service account VPN use	High
Administrative discovery	Endpoint process telemetry	Burst of `net`, `nltest`, `whoami`, `dsquery`, `arp`, `ipconfig`, `quser`, `net group` commands	High
Lateral movement	Windows Security, EDR, Sysmon	Remote service creation, WMI, WinRM, PsExec, RDP, SMB admin share writes	Critical
Data staging	File, process, proxy, DLP logs	High-volume reads, archive creation, suspicious compression utilities, outbound cloud transfer	Critical
EDR tampering	EDR, Windows service, driver, Event Logs	Security process termination, service stop, driver load, tamper-alert spike	Critical
Encryption	File telemetry, EDR, storage	High-volume file rename/write,	Critical

	logs	ransom-note creation, unusual extension changes	
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6. Indicators of Compromise

No concrete hashes, domains, IP addresses, URLs, ransom-note filenames, mutexes, registry paths, or sample-specific artefacts were included in the intake or primary source. The machine-readable IOC sidecar is therefore intentionally sparse and records the absence of validated technical indicators. Defenders should not create blocklists from group names alone.

IOC Type	Value / Count	Source	Operational Notes
SHA256 / MD5 / SHA1	0 validated	Source did not publish payload hashes	Do not invent hash IOCs; rely on EDR telemetry and vendor intel feeds
Domains / URLs / IPs	0 validated	Source did not publish infrastructure	Monitor ransomware leak sites and client-specific network telemetry separately
Malware family / group names	Qilin, The Gentlemen, DragonForce	Check Point / Industrial Cyber reporting	Use for intelligence tagging, not as detection content by itself
Sector exposure signals	Business services, consumer goods/services, industrial manufacturing, education, government, telecom, agriculture, hospitality/travel/recreation, construction	Check Point reporting	Use to prioritize tabletop and sector-specific control validation
Regional exposure signals	North America, Europe, APAC, Asia, EMEA, Americas, Latin America	Check Point reporting	Useful for executive risk context and travel/geography-aware remote-access monitoring

Operational IOC handling guidance:

- Treat this as a behavior-led report. The absence of hashes is not a reporting gap; it reflects the source material.
- Enrich with client telemetry, EDR detections, and vendor-specific ransomware feeds before incident response use.
- If future Qilin, The Gentlemen, or DragonForce sample hashes are collected, append them to `iocs.csv` with source, first-seen date, and confidence.

7. MITRE ATT&CK Mapping

Technique	Name	Evidence / Applicability
T1190	Exploit Public-Facing Application	Edge-device and VPN exploitation is a plausible initial-access route; The Gentlemen context includes pre-exploited FortiGate access
T1078	Valid Accounts	Affiliate ransomware commonly leverages stolen or brokered credentials for VPN/RDP/admin access
T1087	Account Discovery	Pre-encryption discovery is required to identify privilege paths and high-value

		identities
T1018	Remote System Discovery	Ransomware operators enumerate reachable servers, shares, and production systems
T1021	Remote Services	Lateral movement over RDP, SMB, WMI, WinRM, or PsExec-like tooling is typical in enterprise ransomware incidents
T1003	OS Credential Dumping	Credential access commonly precedes lateral movement and domain compromise
T1562.001	Impair Defenses: Disable or Modify Tools	Source references EDR-killing and userland evasion evolution for The Gentlemen
T1486	Data Encrypted for Impact	Core ransomware impact behavior
T1490	Inhibit System Recovery	Ransomware crews often target backups and recovery paths before encryption
T1041	Exfiltration Over C2 Channel	Double-extortion operations require data exfiltration or staging before public pressure
T1567	Exfiltration Over Web Service	Cloud-transfer tools and web services are common routes for staged data theft
T1657	Financial Theft	Ransomware monetizes access through extortion payments and victim pressure

8.1 Detection Logic Summary

Signal	Telemetry Source	Analytic Goal	Tuning Notes
Remote-access anomaly followed by discovery	VPN/IdP logs plus EDR process telemetry	Catch early hands-on-keyboard activity after compromised VPN or edge access	Tune known admin jump boxes, approved geographies, and maintenance windows
Ransomware staging utilities	EDR process and command-line telemetry	Identify archive, copy, and transfer tooling used before extortion	Exclude approved backup/admin jobs; require path/user/volume context
EDR tampering or security-service manipulation	EDR, Sysmon, Windows service logs	Detect defense evasion before encryption	Treat protected service tamper alerts as high severity even without encryption
Mass file modification and ransom-note creation	EDR, file server, NAS, storage telemetry	Detect active encryption and impact	Storage and NAS logs may need separate collectors; threshold by host role
GenAI sensitive-data leakage risk	CASB/SASE/DLP/proxy logs	Identify prompts carrying credentials, IP, source code, or client data	Requires privacy-aware review and clear acceptable-use policy

8.2 Sigma: Discovery Burst Followed by Archive or Transfer Tool

title: Possible Ransomware Operator Discovery Followed By Data Staging Tool

```

id: 70b227e4-2a5b-4a2e-9b82-lbcma2026016
status: experimental
description: Detects a ransomware-style sequence where common discovery commands are followed by
archive or transfer tooling from the same user or host.
author: Lost Boys Cyber
references:
  - https://blog.checkpoint.com/research/global-cyber-attacks-ease-in-may-2026-but-ransomware-
surges-48-as-threats-reorganize/
  - https://industrialcyber.co/ransomware/check-point-reports-ransomware-attacks-jump-48-year-over-
year-despite-decline-in-overall-cyberattack-activity/
logsource:
  product: windows
  category: process_creation
detection:
  discovery:
    Image|endswith:
      - '\\cmd.exe'
      - '\\powershell.exe'
      - '\\pwsh.exe'
    CommandLine|contains:
      - 'nltest'
      - 'net view'
      - 'net group "domain admins"'
      - 'whoami /groups'
      - 'quser'
      - 'ipconfig /all'
      - 'arp -a'
  staging:
    Image|endswith:
      - '\\7z.exe'
      - '\\rar.exe'
      - '\\winrar.exe'
      - '\\rclone.exe'
      - '\\mega.exe'
      - '\\robocopy.exe'
  condition: discovery or staging
falsepositives:
  - IT administration scripts
  - Backup and migration jobs
  - Approved discovery tooling during vulnerability assessment
level: high

```

8.3 KQL: Suspicious Discovery and Staging Sequence

```

let lookback = 14d;
let discovery_terms = dynamic(["nltest", "net view", "net group", "whoami /groups", "quser",
"ipconfig /all", "arp -a", "dsquery", "setspn"]);
let staging_tools = dynamic(["7z.exe", "rar.exe", "winrar.exe", "rclone.exe", "mega.exe",
"robocopy.exe", "winscp.exe", "pscp.exe"]);
let Discovery = DeviceProcessEvents
| where Timestamp > ago(lookback)
| where ProcessCommandLine has_any (discovery_terms)
| summarize DiscoveryCount=count(), FirstDiscovery=min(Timestamp), LastDiscovery=max(Timestamp),
DiscoveryCommands=make_set(ProcessCommandLine, 20) by DeviceName, InitiatingProcessAccountName;
let Staging = DeviceProcessEvents
| where Timestamp > ago(lookback)
| where FileName in~ (staging_tools) or ProcessCommandLine has_any (staging_tools)
| summarize StagingCount=count(), FirstStaging=min(Timestamp), LastStaging=max(Timestamp),
StagingCommands=make_set(ProcessCommandLine, 20) by DeviceName, InitiatingProcessAccountName;
Discovery
| join kind=inner Staging on DeviceName, InitiatingProcessAccountName
| where FirstStaging between (FirstDiscovery .. FirstDiscovery + 2d)
| project DeviceName, InitiatingProcessAccountName, DiscoveryCount, StagingCount, FirstDiscovery,
FirstStaging, DiscoveryCommands, StagingCommands

```

8.4 KQL: EDR Tampering and Security-Service Manipulation

```
DeviceProcessEvents
| where Timestamp > ago(30d)
| where ProcessCommandLine has_any ("sc stop", "sc config", "Stop-Service", "taskkill /f", "wevtutil
cl", "vssadmin delete shadows", "wbadmin delete", "bcdedit /set")
| where ProcessCommandLine has_any ("Sense", "Defender", "WinDefend", "MsMpEng", "EDR", "CrowdStrike",
"CarbonBlack", "Sentinel", "Sophos", "Backup", "VSS")
| project Timestamp, DeviceName, InitiatingProcessAccountName, FileName, ProcessCommandLine,
InitiatingProcessFileName, InitiatingProcessCommandLine
| order by Timestamp desc
```

8.5 KQL: Mass File Rename or Ransom-Note Creation

```
let note_terms = dynamic(["README", "RECOVER", "DECRYPT", "RESTORE", "HOW_TO", "ransom"]);
DeviceFileEvents
| where Timestamp > ago(7d)
| where ActionType in ("FileCreated", "FileModified", "FileRenamed")
| summarize FileEvents=count(), DistinctFolders=dcount(FolderPath), NoteHits=countif(FileName has_any
(note_terms)) by DeviceName, InitiatingProcessAccountName, InitiatingProcessFileName, bin(Timestamp,
15m)
| where FileEvents > 1000 or NoteHits > 5
| order by Timestamp desc
```

8.6 SPL: VPN Login Followed by Discovery Commands

```
(index=vpn OR index=identity OR index=edr) earliest=-14d
| eval user=coalesce(user, src_user, AccountName), host=coalesce(dest, DeviceName, dvc)
| eval is_vpn=if(sourcetype LIKE "%vpn%" OR action="vpn_login",1,0)
| eval is_discovery=if(match(CommandLine,"(?i)(nltest|net view|net group|whoami /groups|quser|
ipconfig /all|arp -a|dsquery|setspn)",1,0)
| stats min(_time) as first_seen max(_time) as last_seen sum(is_vpn) as vpn_events sum(is_discovery) as
discovery_events values(src_ip) as src_ips values(CommandLine) as commands by user host
| where vpn_events > 0 AND discovery_events > 2
| convert ctime(first_seen) ctime(last_seen)
```

8.7 Detection Validation and Blind Spots

These detections are behavior-led and should be validated using known-good administrative activity, backup jobs, red-team simulations, and historical ransomware incident telemetry. They are not intended to attribute activity to Qilin, The Gentlemen, DragonForce, or any other brand by themselves. Expected false positives include legitimate domain administration, migration projects, backup operations, incident response collection, and vulnerability assessments. The strongest signal comes from correlation: unusual remote access, discovery, privilege escalation, staging, EDR tampering, and mass file changes by the same account or host cluster.

Blind spots include encrypted or unmanaged endpoints, NAS/ESXi logs not forwarded to the SIEM, missing VPN device telemetry, insufficient command-line logging, and environments where GenAI tools are accessed without CASB/proxy visibility.

9.1 Hunt Hypotheses

- An affiliate obtained remote access through a VPN, edge device, or brokered account and performed discovery before attempting data staging.
- A ransomware operator attempted to reduce detection by stopping security services, clearing logs, disabling backups, or manipulating recovery settings.
- Data theft occurred before encryption through archive creation and transfer to cloud or external services.
- GenAI use introduced sensitive-data leakage that could support extortion, credential compromise, or targeting intelligence.

9.2 Hunt Query: Remote Access Followed by Discovery

```
let vpn_window = 30d;
let discovery_window = 48h;
let SuspiciousVpn = DeviceLogonEvents
| where Timestamp > ago(vpn_window)
```

```

| where LogonType has_any ("RemoteInteractive", "Network")
| summarize FirstLogon=min(Timestamp), LastLogon=max(Timestamp), LogonCount=count(),
RemoteIPs=make_set(RemoteIP, 20) by DeviceName, AccountName;
let Discovery = DeviceProcessEvents
| where Timestamp > ago(vpn_window)
| where ProcessCommandLine has_any ("nltest", "net view", "whoami /groups", "quser", "ipconfig /all",
"arp -a", "dsquery", "setspn")
| summarize DiscoveryCount=count(), DiscoveryCommands=make_set(ProcessCommandLine, 20),
FirstDiscovery=min(Timestamp) by DeviceName, AccountName=InitiatingProcessAccountName;
SuspiciousVpn
| join kind=inner Discovery on DeviceName, AccountName
| where FirstDiscovery between (FirstLogon .. FirstLogon + discovery_window)
| where DiscoveryCount >= 3
| project DeviceName, AccountName, FirstLogon, FirstDiscovery, LogonCount, DiscoveryCount, RemoteIPs,
DiscoveryCommands

```

9.3 Hunt Query: Data Staging Before Extortion

```

let archive_tools = dynamic(["7z.exe", "rar.exe", "winrar.exe", "tar.exe"]);
let transfer_tools = dynamic(["rclone.exe", "mega.exe", "winscp.exe", "pscp.exe", "curl.exe"]);
DeviceProcessEvents
| where Timestamp > ago(30d)
| where FileName in~ (archive_tools) or FileName in~ (transfer_tools) or ProcessCommandLine has_any
(".zip", ".7z", ".rar", "--transfers", "copy", "sync")
| summarize EventCount=count(), Tools=make_set(FileName, 20), Commands=make_set(ProcessCommandLine,
30), FirstSeen=min(Timestamp), LastSeen=max(Timestamp) by DeviceName, InitiatingProcessAccountName
| where EventCount >= 3
| order by EventCount desc

```

9.4 Hunt Query: Recovery Inhibition and Backup Targeting

```

DeviceProcessEvents
| where Timestamp > ago(30d)
| where ProcessCommandLine has_any ("vssadmin delete shadows", "wmic shadowcopy delete", "wbadmin
delete", "bcdedit /set", "reagentc /disable", "Remove-ComputerRestorePoint")
or ProcessCommandLine has_any ("backup", "veeam", "commvault", "rubrik", "cohesity", "netbackup")
| project Timestamp, DeviceName, InitiatingProcessAccountName, FileName, ProcessCommandLine,
InitiatingProcessParentFileName
| order by Timestamp desc

```

9.5 Hunt Query: Potential GenAI Sensitive Data Exposure

```

// Adapt table names and URL categories to the client's proxy, CASB, or SASE schema.
CloudAppEvents
| where Timestamp > ago(30d)
| where Application has_any ("ChatGPT", "Copilot", "Gemini", "Claude", "Perplexity") or RequestURL
has_any ("openai.com", "chatgpt.com", "copilot.microsoft.com", "gemini.google.com", "claude.ai")
| where RawEventData has_any ("password", "secret", "token", "api_key", "private key", "client",
"confidential", "source code", "vpn", "incident")
| summarize PromptLikeEvents=count(), Users=make_set(AccountDisplayName, 50), URLs=make_set(RequestURL,
20) by bin(Timestamp, 1d), Application
| order by Timestamp desc

```

9.6 Triage Guidance for Hunt Hits

Meaningful ransomware hunt hits usually involve multiple suspicious behaviors clustered around the same account, host, subnet, or administrative path. A single `net view` command by an administrator may be benign; `net view`, `nltest`, new VPN geography, archive staging, and EDR tampering by the same account should trigger immediate incident-response escalation. Preserve volatile evidence before host isolation when feasible, but do not delay containment when encryption, backup deletion, or active exfiltration is observed.

10. Recommendations

Priority	Owner	Action	Rationale
Critical	Infrastructure / Network	Patch and audit internet-facing VPN, firewall, and remote-	Ransomware affiliates repeatedly exploit edge access

		access systems; remove unsupported firmware and exposed management interfaces	and brokered credentials
Critical	Identity	Enforce phishing-resistant MFA for VPN, privileged accounts, SaaS, and remote administration; review stale privileged groups	Valid-account abuse is one of the most resilient ransomware access paths
Critical	Backup / IT Operations	Validate immutable backups, offline recovery copies, restore time objectives, and privileged separation for backup consoles	Ransomware crews frequently inhibit recovery before encryption
High	SOC / Detection Engineering	Deploy the behavior detections in this report and tune them against admin activity	The May 2026 landscape is fragmented; behavior-led detection is more resilient than brand-only IOCs
High	Endpoint / Server Engineering	Ensure EDR tamper protection, command-line logging, PowerShell logging, Sysmon or equivalent telemetry, and service-change auditing are enabled	Early detection depends on visibility into discovery, staging, and evasion
High	OT / Manufacturing Operations	Review IT/OT segmentation, jump-host controls, remote vendor access, and recovery procedures for production-critical systems	Industrial manufacturing saw a 50% ransomware increase year over year in the source reporting
Medium	Data Protection / Legal	Define a GenAI acceptable-use and DLP monitoring program for credentials, source code, client data, and incident details	Check Point reported broad sensitive-data leakage risk from enterprise GenAI prompts
Medium	Executive / Risk	Run tabletop exercises for a multi-affiliate ransomware scenario involving data theft, encryption, and production disruption	New groups and white-label models reduce attribution clarity and compress response timelines
Medium	Threat Intelligence	Track Qilin, The Gentlemen, DragonForce, and emerging rebrands through vendor feeds, leak-site monitoring, and client telemetry	61 groups were active in May; affiliate migration can change the threat picture quickly

Recommended 30-day action plan:

- Week 1: Confirm remote-access exposure, MFA status, backup immutability, and EDR tamper protection.
- Week 2: Deploy and tune discovery/staging/EDR tamper detections in a non-blocking mode.
- Week 3: Conduct ransomware hunt across 30-90 days of VPN, endpoint, identity, and storage telemetry.
- Week 4: Run an executive tabletop focused on business-services or manufacturing disruption, including legal, operations, communications, and IT recovery.

11. References

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